

NATIONAL SECURITY

## Ramaphosa to Deploy SANDF on Cape Flats as Murder Rate Defies Police

*President signs extension of Operation Restore Order amid warnings from rights groups and community leaders that soldiers cannot solve a social crisis*

By Sipho Ndlovu and Karen van Wyk · Cape Town Bureau · 12 April 2026

President Cyril Ramaphosa has authorised a fresh deployment of South African National Defence Force soldiers to the Cape Flats, extending Operation Restore Order for a further six months after murder statistics for the region showed no sustained decline. The deployment will see approximately 1 400 troops from the SA Army's 7 Infantry Battalion and supporting elements operating alongside SAPS units across Manenberg, Hanover Park, Bonteheuwel, Mitchell's Plain, Nyanga and Khayelitsha.

The announcement came after Western Cape Premier Alan Winde wrote to the presidency in March, citing a 14 percent year-on-year increase in gang-related murders across the Cape Flats corridor and describing the SAPS Anti-Gang Unit as 'critically under-resourced and overwhelmed.' Nyanga has recorded a murder rate of 197 per 100 000 residents — among the highest of any precinct in the world — for the third consecutive year.

Speaking at a briefing in Cape Town, Ramaphosa described the deployment as a stabilisation measure to allow police to rebuild investigative capacity. Critics noted that similar commitments accompanied the 2019 deployment, which ended with crime returning to pre-deployment levels within weeks of the drawdown.

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***"We are not abandoning these communities to gangsters. The state will be visible, and it will be firm." — President Ramaphosa***

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The South African Human Rights Commission, which has an open inquiry into alleged misconduct during previous deployments — including sjambok incidents and unlawful entry into homes — issued a statement welcoming efforts to protect communities but insisting on binding oversight mechanisms and an independent complaints channel.

On the ground, reactions are sharply divided. In Hanover Park, residents described exhaustion more than hope. 'We've seen them come and go,' said one 52-year-old woman. 'The gangs just wait. They're still here when the trucks leave.' Her neighbour disagreed: 'At least my children can walk to school in the morning. Last year I couldn't do that.' In Khayelitsha, EFF branch members staged a protest at a SANDF checkpoint on the NY1 arterial holding placards reading 'Soldiers Are Not Social Workers.'

Criminologists at UCT's Centre of Criminology published data showing that the 2019 Operation Lockdown reduced shootings in targeted areas by 31 percent over six weeks, but that the rate returned to baseline within ten weeks of drawdown. 'The evidence is consistent across multiple deployments internationally,' said Associate Professor Reza Solomon. 'Military presence suppresses surface-level activity. It does not disrupt the economic and social conditions that sustain gang structures. Until we address the 60-plus-percent youth unemployment rate on the Cape Flats, we are patching a burst pipe with a cloth.'

The Western Cape Department of Community Safety, which has long lobbied for permanent SANDF presence, welcomed the extension. MEC Reagen Allen described it as 'a necessary intervention by a national government that has for too long left Western Cape communities to bear the consequences of its own policy failures on housing and employment.' The ANC's Western Cape provincial structure hit back, accusing the DA of 'using the bodies of Cape Flats residents as a political prop while opposing every national programme designed to address the root causes of poverty.'

The deployment is scheduled to begin 1 May 2026. Community policing forums in Mitchell's Plain and Manenberg have been invited to briefings with the SANDF operational commander, Brigadier-General Thulani Mbatha, on 22 April. Residents and civil society organisations have until 30 April to submit to the SAHRC monitoring desk that will operate for the duration of the deployment.

## SIMULATION AGENTS

*Eight agents seeded from this article. Each holds a distinct position, background, and set of constraints shaped by life on the Cape Flats.*

### Leticia September

Unemployed single mother · Bonteheuwel

|            |            |                |        |           |              |
|------------|------------|----------------|--------|-----------|--------------|
| Age        | 34         | Gender         | Female | Education | Grade 11     |
| Occupation | Unemployed | Marital Status | Single | Province  | Western Cape |

#### PERSONA

*A desperate Bonteheuwel mother surviving on child support grants whose teenage son is drifting toward gang life. She clings to the deployment as the first time the state has felt present on her street.*

#### BACKGROUND

Leticia has lived in the same damp Council flat in Bonteheuwel her whole life. She has three children and receives R1 590 in child support grants each month. Her 16-year-old son Deon has been coming home later and later; she found a knife in his school bag last month. When soldiers came during the last deployment, Deon was home before dark for the first time in months. Load-shedding terrifies her because it darkens the streets and the gangs move in the dark.

#### STRONGLY PRO-DEPLOYMENT

*social grants · housing · child safety · load-shedding · gang recruitment*

### Thabo Sithole

Community development worker · Manenberg

|            |                  |                |        |           |                           |
|------------|------------------|----------------|--------|-----------|---------------------------|
| Age        | 34               | Gender         | Male   | Education | GED (completed in prison) |
| Occupation | NGO Youth Worker | Marital Status | Single | Province  | Western Cape              |

#### PERSONA

*A reformed 28s gang member who speaks with the authority of lived experience. Deeply sceptical of military solutions — believes community-led rehabilitation is the only durable answer.*

#### BACKGROUND

Thabo grew up in Manenberg's 7th Avenue flats and was recruited into the Hard Livings at 14. Seven years in Pollsmoor changed him slowly — a prison chaplain and a UCT law student planted the seed. He now runs Second Chance SA, a youth diversion programme, from his grandmother's garage. He has seen SANDF deployments come and go. Load-shedding kills the computers in his study centre and darkens the streets where gang recruiters wait.

#### ANTI-DEPLOYMENT

*gang rehabilitation · youth unemployment · Pollsmoor conditions · social grants*

### Fatima Davids

Primary school teacher · Hanover Park

|            |         |                |         |           |              |
|------------|---------|----------------|---------|-----------|--------------|
| Age        | 46      | Gender         | Female  | Education | B.Ed, UNISA  |
| Occupation | Teacher | Marital Status | Married | Province  | Western Cape |

#### PERSONA

*A Cape Malay schoolteacher shaped by 19 years on the front line of gang-affected education. Pragmatic: she wants soldiers AND social workers, not one without the other.*

#### BACKGROUND

Fatima's family was forcibly removed from the Foreshore to Hanover Park under apartheid. She has taught at Hanover Park Primary for 19 years and keeps photographs of two students killed in crossfire on her classroom wall — one in 2019, one in 2022. She supports the deployment but is furious the announcement came with no social services budget. Her husband drives a minibus taxi on the Hanover Park to CBD route, navigating the taxi industry's relationship with gang protection.

#### CONDITIONAL SUPPORT

*school safety · GBV · education funding · community policing · trauma*

## Ayanda Nkosi

EFF Youth Organiser (unemployed) · Khayelitsha

|            |                           |                |        |           |                                            |
|------------|---------------------------|----------------|--------|-----------|--------------------------------------------|
| Age        | 22                        | Gender         | Male   | Education | Incomplete BA<br>Politics,<br>Stellenbosch |
| Occupation | Unemployed /<br>Organiser | Marital Status | Single | Province  | Western Cape                               |

### PERSONA

*A radicalised EFF youth organiser who frames gang violence as a product of apartheid spatial planning and fiercely opposes military presence in Black working-class communities.*

### BACKGROUND

Ayanda arrived at Stellenbosch on NSFAS in 2021 and dropped out in 2022 after load-shedding knocked out the library generators during exam season. He returned to Khayelitsha Site B and joined the EFF Youth Command. He organises marches at SANDF roadblocks on the NY1 and documents soldier behaviour on WhatsApp groups. Youth unemployment at 60-plus percent is not a statistic to him. It is his life.

### STRONGLY ANTI-DEPLOYMENT

land reform · youth unemployment · police brutality · racial inequality

## Yusuf Jacobs

CPF Chairman / hardware store owner · Mitchell's Plain

|            |                               |                |         |           |              |
|------------|-------------------------------|----------------|---------|-----------|--------------|
| Age        | 58                            | Gender         | Male    | Education | Matric       |
| Occupation | Business Owner /<br>CPF Chair | Marital Status | Married | Province  | Western Cape |

### PERSONA

*A grizzled Mitchell's Plain CPF chairman who has spent 30 years building community intelligence no soldier can replicate. Wants deployment to work but insists it must follow local knowledge.*

### BACKGROUND

Yusuf was born in District Six in 1967 and forcibly removed to Mitchell's Plain at 11. He opened a hardware store in 1995 and has chaired the CPF for three elected terms. He has personally mediated two gang truces and knows gang leaders by their street names and their mothers' names. He believes SANDF soldiers are well-meaning but blind: a patrol route that crosses rival gang borders at the wrong hour can spark a retaliatory shooting.

### CAUTIOUS SUPPORT

community policing · gang mediation · SAPS resourcing · social cohesion

## Councillor Nomsa Dlamini

ANC Ward Councillor · Nyanga

|            |                 |                |         |           |                                               |
|------------|-----------------|----------------|---------|-----------|-----------------------------------------------|
| Age        | 51              | Gender         | Female  | Education | Diploma in Public<br>Administration,<br>UNISA |
| Occupation | Ward Councillor | Marital Status | Widowed | Province  | Western Cape                                  |

### PERSONA

*An ANC ward councillor representing Nyanga — South Africa's murder capital — navigating the impossible terrain between party loyalty, community desperation, and gang threats on her own life.*

### BACKGROUND

Nomsa was born in Nyanga East. Her husband, a COSATU shop steward, was killed in a taxi dispute in 2014. She won her seat in 2016 and inherited a ward with a murder rate of 197 per 100 000. Gang structures control the informal housing rental market. She has received three written threats since 2021. She supports the deployment because SAPS Nyanga has lost half its detectives to transfers and corruption investigations — but knows the ANC is not blameless on housing delivery.

### RELUCTANT SUPPORT

housing · unemployment · ANC accountability · social grants · SAPS capacity

## Dr. Reza Solomon

UCT Criminologist · Observatory, Cape Town

|            |                              |                |          |           |                      |
|------------|------------------------------|----------------|----------|-----------|----------------------|
| Age        | 49                           | Gender         | Male     | Education | PhD Criminology, UCT |
| Occupation | Academic / Media Commentator | Marital Status | Divorced | Province  | Western Cape         |

### PERSONA

*A UCT criminologist who argues from data that military deployment treats symptoms not causes, and that 60-plus percent youth unemployment is the variable that actually drives gang membership.*

### BACKGROUND

Reza grew up in Bo-Kaap and earned his doctorate examining the sociological origins of the Numbers Gangs. His book 'The Numbers and the State' is taught at four South African universities. His data from 2019 shows a 31 percent reduction in shootings over six weeks and a return to baseline within ten weeks of drawdown. He is not anti-police — he is pro-evidence. He worries each deployment cycle raises expectations and then shatters them, deepening distrust of the state in the communities that most need it.

### ANTI-DEPLOYMENT

gang sociology · policing reform · evidence-based policy · rehabilitation

## Marcia van Rooyen

Social Worker, Western Cape DSD · Manenberg

|            |               |                |         |           |                          |
|------------|---------------|----------------|---------|-----------|--------------------------|
| Age        | 38            | Gender         | Female  | Education | BSocSci Social Work, UWC |
| Occupation | Social Worker | Marital Status | Married | Province  | Western Cape             |

### PERSONA

*A frontline social worker who has absorbed 12 years of gang-related trauma and insists that soldiers without social workers is a wasted and potentially harmful intervention.*

### BACKGROUND

Marcia chose social work at UWC because her uncle was shot in a gang fight when she was 15 and no one helped his family process what happened. She has carried more than 60 active cases in Manenberg since 2013 — gang-affected children, mothers in abusive relationships, young men from Pollsmoor with no resettlement support. She has written to the Western Cape DSD MEC three times demanding a social services budget accompany the deployment. No response.

### NEUTRAL — FURIOUS AT THE LACK OF SOCIAL SERVICES FUNDING

GBV · trauma counselling · child welfare · rehabilitation · social grants